THE SANTA BARBARA Independent ONLINE
The County's News and Entertainment Paper

HOME
COVER
NEWS
news briefs
news features
ARTS & ENTERTAINMENT
arts feature
week
art
pop, rock & jazz
classical
best bets
sound & fury
film
food
LIVING
living feature
my life
history 101
gardening
peeps
OPINIONS
angry poodle
letters
voices
CLASSIFIEDS
employment
real estate
well-being
auto
marketplace
services
bulletin board
music/ musicians
adult

SPECIAL ISSUES
best of 2003
wedding guide
after school guide
summer camp guide

ADVERTISING INFO
rate cards
distribution

BY MATT KETTMANN, CATHY MURILLO, and NICK WELSH,
with Drew Atkins and Ethan Stewart

QUOTE OF THE WEEK

'I've been talking trash for 10 years now.'
— Goleta City Council member Jonny Wallis, on no longer serving on the county's solid waste task force.

GONZO FOR GAUCHOS

In front of a rowdy crowd of 11,000-plus at Harder Stadium last Saturday, the UCSB men's soccer team thoroughly trounced the Virginia Commonwealth Rams 4-1, securing their first-ever Division 1A Final Four appearance. The Rams jumped on the scoreboard first, scoring only four minutes into the game. But Gaucho defender Andy Iro answered back about 30 minutes later, slipping a shot into the Rams' net by redirecting a corner kick from fellow defender Tony Lockheed.

While the first half saw the Rams firing multiple shots on Gaucho goalie Dan Kennedy, UCSB owned the second half. The 1-1 tie was broken by midfielder Bryan Byrne when he trapped a pass from forward Drew McAthy with his chest and socked it into the goal. Forward Andrew Proctor used another pass from McAthy to score the Gauchos' third goal of the night. Iro, who nailed the Gauchos' first goal, sealed the deal with the fourth and final goal, utilizing another corner kick from Lockheed.

The action didn't stop at game's end, however. In the game's final minute, a streaker dashed across the field, wearing nothing but a wool hat and socks. Then when the clock hit zero, rabid Gaucho fans swarmed onto the field and hoisted players and a goal into the air. Fans then carried the goal down the street in celebration, intent on throwing it into the ocean. But the police stopped them at El Colegio Road, and the goal was saved.

The Gauchos next face Duke University at 7:30 p.m. on Friday, December 10, at the Home Depot Center in Carson, California, just south of Los Angeles. A first semifinal visit for the Gauchos, the game also marks the first time a Final Four match has been played in California since 1981. If the Gauchos win that game, they would go on to play in the championship match on Sunday against either Indiana or Maryland, further extending what is already a dream season.

PROMOTIONS & EVENTS
CURRENT PRINT AD SPECIALS.
INDY SPONSORED EVENTS.
CLASSIFIED SPECIALS.

MONTECITO MOTORS


Rigs to Reefs

Who benefits - oil companies or rockfish?

By Ethan Stewart

The 27 oil platforms off the coast of Southern California - most of which are right here in the Santa Barbara Channel - have over the years become artificial reefs for sea dwellers such as the embattled rockfish. The rigs are slated for removal when the oil fields dry up, which could be as early as 2010, and the expected price tag for removing all platforms - approximately 75 football fields of surface area - is expected to be as much as $2 billion. With three to five years of permitting required, this future issue is fast becoming today's dilemma.

As such, the Santa Barbara chapter of the Surfrider Foundation - which has not yet taken a stance on the issue - last week invited George Steinbach, the executive director of the California Reef Enhancement

Program (CARE), to speak at a December 2 Surfrider meeting on the topic of converting rigs to reefs. Citing research by UCSB marine expert Milton Love, Steinbach explained that the rigs serve as more than adequate habitat to many different forms of sea life and that absolute removal of the platforms might not be the best solution for the ocean. Steinbach added that a survey should be done and suggested that the rigs providing the best habitat should simply have their tops lopped off and be left in place. The money saved by oil companies, he proposed, could then go into an ocean-related state trust.

The CARE stance was not without detractors. Many in attendance were quick to point out that CARE gets a vast majority of its funding from the oil industry. In addition, the point was made that no matter what is done with the rigs, any structure made of carbon steel that stays in the water will eventually erode to the point of collapse, thus destroying the artificial reef habitat and perhaps creating an environmental problem that could have been otherwise prevented. The estimated time frame for such erosion varies from 100 to 200 years. More debate is sure to come.

Doctor Dan Goes Coastal

By Nick Welsh

Santa Barbara City Council member and retired gynecologist Dan Secord was appointed to the California Coastal Commission by Governor Arnold Schwarzenegger just in time to participate in a contentious vote on the commission's new chair and vice chair at this week's meeting - and weigh in on controversial new nuclear waste storage plans for the Diablo Canyon Nuclear Power Plant.

Although Secord - the sole Republican on the City Council - has never been embraced by the South Coast's environmental community, many activists regard him as hardworking, direct, and independent-minded - someone with whom they can find common ground. He was assisted in his quest for the appointment by recommendations from the Community Environmental Council (CEC) and Jon Clarke, formerly of CEC and now with the Wendy

P. McCaw Foundation.

Because Secord has only one year left before being termed out of his City Council office, he can serve on the commission for only one year. In that time, Secord said he hoped he could focus on broader policy issues and help fix what's ailing the commission, and avoid the intense political maneuvering that accompanies many commission decisions. "I have no particular agenda," he said. "I'll read the staff reports, keep my head down, and work hard. These are some serious cats."

Hackers Attack!

UCSB hosts international computer security competition

By Drew Atkins

Hostile bits of data raced back and forth across the Atlantic Ocean last Friday as the UCSB Computer Science Department hosted the world's first international computer hacking competition. During the six-hour contest, hackers from 18 universities in the United States, Germany, Italy, and Austria competed to hijack a fake election for president of the world.

Organized by UCSB professor Giovanni Vigna - who teaches a post-graduate course on network security with a hacking competition for the final exam - this year's event was the first such contest on a global scale, though Vigna has hosted U.S.-only competitions in the past. He explained that in order to design good computer security, one must be able to effectively attack - or "hack" - computer systems. The government agrees, which is why both the FBI and the U.S. military were said to be monitoring last Friday's six-hour contest, on the lookout for talented recruits.

With the premise of electing a world president on the United Nations' Web site, teams gained points for successfully hacking the servers of their international competitors, whether to change votes in the election or disrupt the server's operations. The team from Milan, Italy took first place, while UCSB placed seventh.

Kafatia Rape Hearing

By Matt Kettmann

The preliminary hearing in the case against the Santa Barbara City College security guard Kent Wesley Kafatia, accused of raping four women - three while on duty in his capacity as a guard - was held this week, and it appears that Judge George Eskin will be sending it to trial. Run by deputy District Attorney Joyce Dudley, the hearing focused, via police detective Jaycee Hunter's testimony, on the alleged assaults, intimidation, and, in two cases, rapes of Jane Does number three and four, by Kafatia, a 22-year-old Malawi native and UCSB student who had been supported by a group of Peace Corps volunteers from Santa Barbara called "Friends of Kent." Some of those supporters were at the trial, as were the mother and grandmother of Jane Doe number four, 20, who was allegedly raped by Kafatia in the pre-dawn hours of November 14, 2004, after he offered her a ride home in his security truck. That case sparked the investigation that led to three other victims, one of whom - Jane Doe number three, a 51-year-old confessed alcoholic - was

allegedly raped while passed out by Kafatia, who she knew as "Allen Iverson." Kafatia allegedly attempted to rape Jane Doe number one, 25, on December 6, 2003 until she fought him off with a large hairpin. Jane Doe number two, 21, was allegedly grabbed and threatened by Kafatia early in the morning on October 30, 2004 as she was walking to meet a friend on the City College campus. By press deadline, Judge Eskin told Dudley he'd heard enough, and defense attorney Karen Atkins was set to begin cross-examination, the results of which were not available.

BRIEFS

STEELHEAD STILL SAFE? Signaling the expected dismantling of environmental regulation in the wake of President Bush's reelection, the federal agency in charge of saving the steelhead trout from extinction released a proposal last week greatly reducing the fish's "critical habitat," a zone where urbanization, farming, or other human activities are significantly restricted. Impact to the Santa Ynez River and streams along the South Coast is likely to be minimal. Streams on Vandenberg Air Force Base, however, are being exempted from fish protections, under the rationale of national security concerns. Fish advocates say the steelhead is still listed as endangered and any "take" can be prosecuted; the proposal will likely be challenged in court by environmentalists.

FENCES DOWN AT DFP: Santa Barbara city parks crews have removed the fences at Douglas Family Preserve, essentially doing away with the controversial 11-acre buffer zone, but new signs say dogs are not allowed on the trail closest to neighboring homes. People, however, are allowed on every trail in the preserve - a rule that satisfies the California Coastal Commission's concerns about public access at the bluff-top, off-leash dog park. The citizens group DogPAC has yet to take a public position; Tuesday, member Lisa Ann Kelly said she's glad the fences are gone, but noted that the city had once again made decisions without a public hearing. Concerns remain among some DFP users about the vegetation city crews removed when creating the new interior trail.

CHANGES IN GOLETA: The Goleta City Council on Monday chose Jean Blois to serve as mayor for 2005 and Jonny Wallis as mayor pro tem; the council also announced that City Manager Fred Stouder has resigned from his post. Blois, who was passed over in the last rotation, was nominated by Wallis. Blois turned around and nominated Wallis as mayor pro tem - seemingly to send the message that any tension between the two during the November election is now resolved. As for Stouder, who has been with the city for two years, the details of a settlement agreement related to his employment contract won't be released until December 13. Reached at his home, Stouder had no comment. City officials were also mum about the personnel matter, but insiders say the City Council, unhappy with his performance, asked him to resign.

St. Anthony's Settles: Pablo Espinoza, a former St. Anthony's seminary student now suing for sexual abuse, was among the abuse victims the Orange County Diocese agreed to settle with for $100 million late last week. Espinoza's attorney Tim Hale declined to confirm the settlement figure, citing a gag order. Hale said Espinoza was abused three times by Father Michael Harris while attending Mater Dei in Orange County. Unlike many of the Orange County plaintiffs, Espinoza, who now lives in Spain, was not on hand for the emotional announcement of the Orange County settlement.

JACKSON'S DNA Swabbed: As the January trial date for the child molestation charges against pop star Michael Jackson looms, two search warrants were served at his Neverland Ranch over the weekend, with one resulting in the singer providing a DNA sample via saliva swab to Sheriff's deputies. The Sheriff's Department would not comment other than to confirm the searches occurred, but legal experts presume that the searches would only have been allowed by Judge Rodney Melville if new evidence had come to light during the pretrial investigation. The raids came before this week's deadline for prosecutors to turn over all the evidence in the case.

HOMICIDE SUSPECTS PLEAD: Tightly shackled and wearing orange jumpsuits, the three men allegedly involved in the killing of a man in an apparent drug deal gone bad entered tentative pleas of "not guilty" in a Santa Barbara courtroom on Tuesday. Joshua Miracle, 25, joined Robert Ibarra, 31, in pleading not guilty to the charge of homicide. Miracle - his shaved head boasting an oversize "ESG" tattoo - also pleaded not guilty to a litany of other charges. Attorneys for Miracle and Ibarra reserved the right to strike additional charges before the next hearing in March. Robert Gallindo, 40, who rented the apartment on Turnpike Road where the murder of Elias Raymond Silva, 30, occurred in early October, pled not guilty to the charge against him.

Dangerous bedfellows: Energy companies are enjoying an unusually cozy relationship with federal energy industry regulators, and those friendly ties are behind the feds' move to undermine the power of state and local energy authorities to control the same energy companies. So concluded a report by the investigative Center for Public Integrity this week, which used the Freedom of Information Act to uncover letters, emails, and memos between big oil companies and the Federal Energy Regulatory Commission (FERC), the country's supposed watchdog of the energy industry. FERC officials have asserted, against state objections, that they have the sole power in allowing the construction of liquefied natural gas (LNG) terminals on the coast, two of which are proposed off of the Ventura County coastline. A bill expected to be introduced to Congress early next session would make the FERC's assertion law. Congresswoman Lois Capps has condemned this discovery of the "secretive and extremely close relationship that the whole energy industry has with the Bush administration" as "extremely disturbing." Currently, five LNG terminals exist and another 54 are in the works.

Line in the Lawn: The Santa Barbara city council voted unanimously late Tuesday to defend front yard set-backs from modifications and encroachments. Brian Barnwell's argument was that modifications should be granted only when they are absolutely essential or when they help generate affordable housing. The council upheld an appeal of a front-yard set back previously granted to a Sammarkand couple living on Stanley Drive, Kris and Samantha Zacharias. The Zachariases, hoping to build a 300-square-foot addition to make room for their, child due in January, had obtained a modification permit allowing them to encroach four feet into the 20-foot front-yard setback, but neighbors appealed.

Jury Bias Charge Tossed: The California Supreme Court dismissed a legal challenge to the way Santa Barbara jury pools are assembled, arguing that reforms are currently underway to remedy the traditional under-representation of Hispanic jurors in Santa Barbara trials. Attorney Robert Sanger complained that his client, accused murderer Benjamin Ballesteros, could not get a fair trial because Santa Barbara's method for assembling jury pools failed to obtain a fair cross-section of the community. Sanger persuaded Judge Ochoa to rule that the county's jury selection process was constitutionally flawed and in need of reform. Ochoa's action - which created a significant logjam in the county's criminal caseload - was not universally applauded by his fellow judges, who insisted the county court commissioner appeal Ochoa's ruling. While the court of appeals reversed Ochoa, the county hired a nationally recognized jury expert who recommended reforming the selection process; a new system will go into effect in January.

CITIZEN'S ALERT

Thu., Dec. 9

Talking Liquefied Natural Gas: Channel Islands National Marine Sanctuary Advisory Council to host public discussion on liquefied natural gas (LNG) and offshore LNG terminals proposed for Santa Barbara Channel. 6-8:30pm. Ventura City Hall. Call 884-1469.

Toy Drive: S.B. Police Activities League and Santa will collect toys from around town on MTD bus, ending up at police station. 10am. 215 E. Figueroa. Call 331-3119.

Montecito Road Closure: Edison will replace power poles along Schoolhouse Road at Pimiento Lane, continues Dec. 10. 8:30am-7pm. Call 490-0003.

Fri., Dec. 10

Sandy Beacon: Meeting of Beach Erosion Authority for Clean Oceans and Nourishment (BEACON). 9am. Carpinteria City Hall. Call 662-6890.

Celebrate Carmen Lodise: Retirement party for longtime Isla Vista activist; bring I.V. memorabilia. 5-9pm. Javan's Sandwiches, I.V. Call 895-1456.

Local Economy: Leadership Santa Barbara County hosts field trips and discussion about Santa Barbara area's business and tourism issues. 11am-4pm. MTD offices, 550 Olive St. Call 893-7695.

Sat., Dec. 11

Off-Leash Dogs: County parks officials hear public comment on off-leash pilot program at various parks. 10am. Tabano Hollow. Call 681-5651.

Weekly Peace Action: March against Iraq war. 11am. Vera Cruz Park. Call 685-8822.

Sun., Dec. 12

Arlington West: Memorial to fallen military personnel in Iraq. 8am until dark. Beach near Stearns Wharf. Call 965-4636.

Mon., Dec. 13

Carp City Council: Regular meeting. 5:30pm. Carp City Hall. Call 684-5405.

Airport Noise: S.B. Airport invites public to give opinions about proposed noise abatement measures. 7-8:30pm. Airport offices, 601 Firestone Rd., Goleta. Call 967-7111.

Thu., Dec. 16

Pilot House Motel: City planning commission hears proposal to demolish old, vacant motel on airport property. 1pm. S.B. City Hall. Call 564-5470.

Ongoing

Youth Awards: Nominate a teen leader for the Harriet Miller Youth Leadership Award, deadline Jan. 5. Call 897-2650.

Notices to news@independent.com; deadline is Fri. prior to publication date.